

That is what I eventually ended up doing. By the time I was a senior, I had a quote screen in my apartment. But, at this point, I had already paid the flat fee for trading for six months. I was trading the markets pretty actively. At one point, I was up over \$10,000, which was an incredible amount to me. At the time, you could have bought two cars for that amount of money. I couldn't believe how easy it was to make money. You just bought something, and it went up. This was in 1979 when commodities were going ballistic.

On what basis were you making your trading decisions?

I really had no idea what I was doing. I would buy something, and when it went up, I would sell it. I was making money because I was buying in a rising market. I can actually say that I bought silver at \$50, which is right near the all-time high. Then Volcker raised interest rates sharply to fight inflation and, on top of that, the exchange raised silver margins. Shortly afterwards, silver prices collapsed. The market went into a string of limit down days.³ I couldn't do anything. I felt helpless, stupid, and powerless. Silver fell all the way down to \$26 before it started trading. It was a gut-wrenching experience.

Did you get out as soon as it started trading?

The first day it traded, I got out. I lost all the money I had made plus some of the money I started with.

Did you stop trading after the big silver loss?

I took some time to reassess the situation. I read a lot of books on speculation. I had enough money left over to start trading futures. I hit it off well with a broker and opened an account with him. Much to my surprise as soon as I opened the account, I was assigned to another broker that actually traded the account. The broker I liked was just a marketing guy. Anyway, the next thing I knew I was long sugar, corn spreads, and other trades. He was a churn 'em and burn 'em broker. That account didn't last long.

Then I opened an account at the local Heinhold commodity branch in Columbia, Missouri. I think I only had a few thousand left. This time around, I was doing all the trading myself. A couple of friends gave me